



CAREERSENSE ACADEMY

Customer Research & User Interviews

Research planning, interviews, surveys, synthesis, personas, insight quality, ethics, and product decisions

PARTNER LEARNING SERIES

Learn how to collect trustworthy customer evidence, avoid biased questions, synthesize qualitative data, and turn research into decisions rather than anecdotes.

CareerSense Partners • product teams • designers • marketers • founders

CareerSense Learning Series • careersenseai.com/resources

FRONT MATTER

How to Use This Handbook

Learn how to collect trustworthy customer evidence, avoid biased questions, synthesize qualitative data, and turn research into decisions rather than anecdotes.

What each chapter contains

Each chapter follows the same learning rhythm used across the CareerSense Academy series: a concise introduction, learning objectives, plain-English concepts, CareerSense examples, professional habits, common mistakes, quick revision notes, practice questions, and hands-on exercises.

PARTNER PROMISE The examples are designed to prepare you for real CareerSense Partner assignments. Do not memorize terminology. Learn to create useful work products: audits, reports, prototypes, dashboards, campaigns, strategies, and decisions.

Recommended practice approach

- Read the relevant chapter before starting the matching Partner assignment.
- Use CareerSense or a safe sample environment to practise whenever possible.
- Keep evidence: screenshots, notes, links, spreadsheets, queries, designs, or metrics.
- Document assumptions and limitations instead of hiding uncertainty.
- Finish each chapter by completing at least one hands-on exercise.

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What You Will Learn

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Closing the book: quick revision sheet • glossary • professional habits • 20-question quiz • answer key • next steps.

CHAPTER 01

01

Research Questions and Study Design

Good research starts with a decision or uncertainty, not a vague desire to 'talk to users'.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Define research objectives
- Choose qualitative or quantitative methods
- Recruit relevant participants
- Recognize research limitations

Core idea

Good research starts with a decision or uncertainty, not a vague desire to 'talk to users'.

Professional perspective

Choose methods based on the question: interviews for depth, surveys for broader patterns, usability testing for interaction, analytics for observed behavior.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

A CareerSense study might ask why users stop after generating an ATS report instead of asking whether they 'like the ATS feature'.

Practice lens	What it means
Weak approach	Start with activity or opinion without defining the desired outcome.
Professional approach	Define the decision, evidence, owner, success measure, and next action.
Evidence to keep	Notes, screenshots, metrics, links, artifacts, or stakeholder feedback.

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Define research objectives.
- Choose qualitative or quantitative methods.
- Recruit relevant participants.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

- Q1** What is the main purpose of research questions and study design?
- Q2** How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?
- Q3** What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?
- Q4** What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to research questions and study design using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 02

02

Recruitment and Sampling

Recruit people whose real behavior and context match the question. A small but relevant sample is more useful than a large unrelated sample.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Define participant criteria
- Avoid convenient-only samples
- Manage incentives
- Document sample limitations

Core idea

Recruit people whose real behavior and context match the question. A small but relevant sample is more useful than a large unrelated sample.

Professional perspective

Avoid presenting qualitative findings as population statistics.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

For job-search research, include students, fresh graduates, career switchers, and working professionals when those segments matter.

Practice lens	What it means
Question to ask	What user or business problem are we trying to solve?
Risk to test	What assumption could make this work fail or produce little value?
Completion signal	What observable result proves the assignment is done well?

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Define participant criteria.
- Avoid convenient-only samples.
- Manage incentives.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

Q1 What is the main purpose of recruitment and sampling?

Q2 How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?

Q3 What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?

Q4 What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to recruitment and sampling using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 03

03

Interview Guides and Neutral Questions

Ask about specific past events: what happened, what they did, what was difficult, what alternatives they used, and how they decided.

LEARNING
OBJECTIVES

- Write open questions
- Use follow-ups
- Avoid leading language
- Explore past behavior

Core idea

Ask about specific past events: what happened, what they did, what was difficult, what alternatives they used, and how they decided.

Professional perspective

Questions such as 'Would you use this?' invite speculation.

CAREERSENSE
CONNECTION

Ask 'Tell me about the last time you prepared for an interview' before describing CareerSense interview simulation.

Practice lens	What it means
Weak approach	Start with activity or opinion without defining the desired outcome.
Professional approach	Define the decision, evidence, owner, success measure, and next action.
Evidence to keep	Notes, screenshots, metrics, links, artifacts, or stakeholder feedback.

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION
NOTES

- Write open questions.
- Use follow-ups.
- Avoid leading language.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

Q1 What is the main purpose of interview guides and neutral questions?

Q2 How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?

Q3 What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?

Q4 What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to interview guides and neutral questions using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 04

04

Conducting Interviews

The researcher's job is to learn, not persuade. Allow silence, ask for examples, and separate the participant's words from your interpretation.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Build rapport
- Listen actively
- Probe without coaching
- Capture consent and notes

Core idea

The researcher's job is to learn, not persuade. Allow silence, ask for examples, and separate the participant's words from your interpretation.

Professional perspective

Respect privacy and collect only information necessary for the study.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

Partners should not request sensitive personal information that is unnecessary for CareerSense product learning.

Practice lens	What it means
Question to ask	What user or business problem are we trying to solve?
Risk to test	What assumption could make this work fail or produce little value?
Completion signal	What observable result proves the assignment is done well?

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Build rapport.
- Listen actively.
- Probe without coaching.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

Q1 What is the main purpose of conducting interviews?

Q2 How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?

Q3 What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?

Q4 What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to conducting interviews using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 05

05

Synthesis and Affinity Mapping

Synthesis turns raw notes into patterns. Group evidence by goals, triggers, barriers, workarounds, expectations, and consequences.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Code interview notes
- Group patterns
- Separate observation from inference
- Identify tensions and segments

Core idea

Synthesis turns raw notes into patterns. Group evidence by goals, triggers, barriers, workarounds, expectations, and consequences.

Professional perspective

Preserve contradictory evidence instead of forcing consensus.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

Create an affinity map of resume, ATS, interview, certification, and career-guidance pain points.

Practice lens	What it means
Weak approach	Start with activity or opinion without defining the desired outcome.
Professional approach	Define the decision, evidence, owner, success measure, and next action.
Evidence to keep	Notes, screenshots, metrics, links, artifacts, or stakeholder feedback.

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Code interview notes.
- Group patterns.
- Separate observation from inference.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

- Q1** What is the main purpose of synthesis and affinity mapping?
- Q2** How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?
- Q3** What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?
- Q4** What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to synthesis and affinity mapping using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 06

06

Personas, Journey Maps, and Insights

A useful insight connects observed behavior to an underlying need or constraint and suggests why it matters.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Create evidence-based personas
- Map journeys
- Write actionable insights
- Avoid stereotypes

Core idea

A useful insight connects observed behavior to an underlying need or constraint and suggests why it matters.

Professional perspective

Personas should support design and prioritization decisions, not become decorative profiles.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

A 'final-year student preparing for first placement season' persona can organize distinct needs from an experienced career switcher.

Practice lens	What it means
Question to ask	What user or business problem are we trying to solve?
Risk to test	What assumption could make this work fail or produce little value?
Completion signal	What observable result proves the assignment is done well?

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Create evidence-based personas.
- Map journeys.
- Write actionable insights.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

- Q1** What is the main purpose of personas, journey maps, and insights?
- Q2** How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?
- Q3** What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?
- Q4** What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to personas, journey maps, and insights using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 07

07

Surveys and Feedback Systems

Surveys work best for measuring known dimensions across more people. They are weaker for discovering unknown motivations.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Write clear survey questions
- Use scales carefully
- Avoid double-barreled items
- Build ongoing feedback loops

Core idea

Surveys work best for measuring known dimensions across more people. They are weaker for discovering unknown motivations.

Professional perspective

Keep survey wording neutral and response options mutually understandable.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

CareerSense can combine post-task satisfaction, open comments, and behavior metrics for a richer feedback system.

Practice lens	What it means
Weak approach	Start with activity or opinion without defining the desired outcome.
Professional approach	Define the decision, evidence, owner, success measure, and next action.
Evidence to keep	Notes, screenshots, metrics, links, artifacts, or stakeholder feedback.

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Write clear survey questions.
- Use scales carefully.
- Avoid double-barreled items.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

Q1 What is the main purpose of surveys and feedback systems?

Q2 How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?

Q3 What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?

Q4 What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to surveys and feedback systems using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CHAPTER 08

08

CareerSense Capstone: Voice of the User

Conduct structured interviews across students, job seekers, and working professionals. Synthesize recurring pains, current alternatives, trust issues, and feature opportunities.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Interview seven users
- Synthesize patterns
- Create personas and journey maps
- Recommend product actions

Core idea

Conduct structured interviews across students, job seekers, and working professionals. Synthesize recurring pains, current alternatives, trust issues, and feature opportunities.

CAREERSENSE CONNECTION

Deliver interview notes, affinity map, top 10 findings, personas, journey map, and five prioritized recommendations.

Practice lens	What it means
Question to ask	What user or business problem are we trying to solve?
Risk to test	What assumption could make this work fail or produce little value?
Completion signal	What observable result proves the assignment is done well?

COMMON MISTAKE

Producing a polished artifact without showing the evidence, assumptions, decision logic, and measurable outcome behind it.

QUICK REVISION NOTES

- Interview seven users.
- Synthesize patterns.
- Create personas and journey maps.
- Tie recommendations to evidence and expected impact.
- Communicate constraints and uncertainty clearly.

Practice Questions

Q1 What is the main purpose of careersense capstone: voice of the user?

Q2 How would you apply this topic to a CareerSense Partner assignment?

Q3 What evidence would you collect before making a recommendation?

Q4 What is one common mistake a beginner should avoid?

Hands-on Exercises

- 1 Create a one-page working artifact related to careersense capstone: voice of the user using CareerSense or a safe sample scenario.
- 2 Review your artifact as if you were a startup leader: identify one missing assumption, one risk, and one measurable improvement.
- 3 Write a 150-word executive summary explaining what you found and what should happen next.

CLOSING THE BOOK

Course Summary

You have worked through the professional foundations of customer research & user interviews. The purpose of this handbook is not to make you fluent in vocabulary; it is to help you complete real work with stronger judgment, structure, evidence, and communication.

**PROFESSIONAL
TAKEAWAY**

CareerSense Partners should be able to explain not only what they did, but why it mattered, what evidence supported it, what trade-offs existed, and what measurable action should happen next.

Customer Research & User Interviews - Quick Revision Sheet

Topic	Remember
Research Questions and Study Design	Define research objectives
Recruitment and Sampling	Define participant criteria
Interview Guides and Neutral Questions	Write open questions
Conducting Interviews	Build rapport
Synthesis and Affinity Mapping	Code interview notes
Personas, Journey Maps, and Insights	Create evidence-based personas
Surveys and Feedback Systems	Write clear survey questions
CareerSense Capstone: Voice of the User	Interview seven users

Glossary

Term	Plain-English meaning
Affinity mapping	Grouping qualitative observations into patterns.
Leading question	A question that pushes a participant toward a preferred answer.
Persona	Evidence-based representation of a user type and their needs.
Outcome	A measurable change in user, customer, or business behavior.
Metric	A quantitative measure used to monitor performance or progress.
Hypothesis	A testable statement about what change is expected and why.
Stakeholder	A person or group affected by or able to influence an initiative.
MVP	The smallest trustworthy version that tests an important assumption.
KPI	A key performance indicator tied to an important objective.
Iteration	A cycle of building, measuring, learning, and improving.
Trade-off	Choosing one benefit or priority while accepting a cost elsewhere.
Evidence	Observed information that supports or challenges a decision.
Prioritization	Deciding what deserves attention and resources first.

20-Question Practice Quiz

1. What is one core principle from 'Research Questions and Study Design'?
9. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Research Questions and Study Design' in a real assignment?
2. What is one core principle from 'Recruitment and Sampling'?
10. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Recruitment and Sampling' in a real assignment?
3. What is one core principle from 'Interview Guides and Neutral Questions'?
11. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Interview Guides and Neutral Questions' in a real assignment?
4. What is one core principle from 'Conducting Interviews'?
12. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Conducting Interviews' in a real assignment?
5. What is one core principle from 'Synthesis and Affinity Mapping'?
13. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Synthesis and Affinity Mapping' in a real assignment?
6. What is one core principle from 'Personas, Journey Maps, and Insights'?
14. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Personas, Journey Maps, and Insights' in a real assignment?
7. What is one core principle from 'Surveys and Feedback Systems'?
15. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'Surveys and Feedback Systems' in a real assignment?
8. What is one core principle from 'CareerSense Capstone: Voice of the User'?
16. How could a CareerSense Partner apply 'CareerSense Capstone: Voice of the User' in a real assignment?
17. Why should recommendations be tied to evidence?
18. What is the difference between an activity and an outcome?
19. Why should assumptions and limitations be documented?
20. What makes an assignment deliverable useful to leadership?

Answer Key

1. A strong answer should explain define research objectives and connect it to an observable decision or result.
9. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
2. A strong answer should explain define participant criteria and connect it to an observable decision or result.
10. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
3. A strong answer should explain write open questions and connect it to an observable decision or result.
11. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
4. A strong answer should explain build rapport and connect it to an observable decision or result.
12. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
5. A strong answer should explain code interview notes and connect it to an observable decision or result.
13. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
6. A strong answer should explain create evidence-based personas and connect it to an observable decision or result.
14. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
7. A strong answer should explain write clear survey questions and connect it to an observable decision or result.
15. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
8. A strong answer should explain interview seven users and connect it to an observable decision or result.
16. Apply the concept using a specific CareerSense workflow, evidence, deliverable, and measurable outcome.
17. Evidence separates a useful recommendation from an unsupported opinion.
18. An activity is work performed; an outcome is the change produced by that work.
19. Documenting assumptions makes uncertainty visible and allows reviewers to judge the strength of the conclusion.
20. A useful deliverable is clear, evidence-based, actionable, appropriately scoped, and tied to an owner or next decision.

CAREERSENSE ACADEMY

Keep Building

You now have a working foundation in customer research & user interviews. Use this handbook as a reference before and during your Partner assignments. Professional capability grows when you repeatedly turn concepts into useful outputs, receive feedback, and improve your judgment.

NEXT STEPS

- Choose the CareerSense Partner assignment most closely related to this handbook.
- Review the relevant chapter before beginning.
- Complete the assignment with traceable evidence.
- Ask for feedback on both the result and your decision process.
- Add the finished work to your Partner portfolio where permitted.

**CAREERSENSE
PARTNER
LEARNING PATH**

Learn → Apply → Document → Review → Improve → Lead.

More CareerSense learning resources

careersenseai.com/resources